

Grading and valuing diamonds

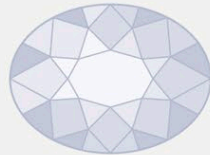
The most precious gem of all

In general, intensely coloured natural diamonds command very high prices. However, “colourless” diamonds, because they have a generally higher value than most “coloured” stones, are graded by a more complex system. A single change in grade can result in a large difference in value. To avoid the large

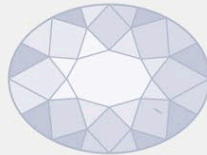
value changes between the grades that would occur if there were only a few grades, there are numerous grades based on each of the four “Cs” (see p.30), thus keeping the changes in value relatively small. The grades and their determinates below are those of the Gemological Institute of America (GIA).

Clarity grading scale The clarity scale runs in stages from visually flawless to stones with numerous visible inclusions.

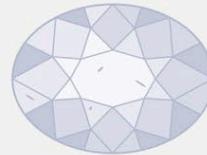
IF (Internally flawless)



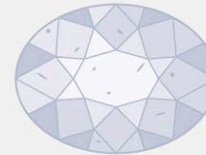
VVS1, VVS2 (Very, very slightly included 1 and 2)



VS1, VS2 (Very slightly included 1 and 2)



S11, SI2 (Slightly included 1 and 2)



I1, I2, I3 (Included 1, 2, and 3)



Colour grading scale The most common colour tint for “white” diamonds is yellow. This scale grades colour according to the amount of yellow present, beginning at “D” for colourless, all the way to “Z” for light yellow (also brown or grey).

D	E	F	G	H	I	J	K	L	M	N	O	P	Q	R	S	T	U	V	W	X	Y	Z
Colourless			Near colourless				Faint yellow			Very light yellow								Light yellow				

Type I gems

Gemstones of Type I level are usually “eye-clean” as standard, with no visible inclusions. Stones in this category are usually of such high clarity that they will be free of even minor inclusions. For lapidaries, collectors, and jewellers, these stones represent the height of desirability.



Type II gems

Gems of the Type II category typically display some inclusions that are visible to the naked eye but do not detract from the desirability and overall beauty of the gemstone. Many such stones with visible inclusions are faceted for use in jewellery.



Type III gems

The Type III classification is mainly applied to gemstones that feature obvious inclusions or other imperfections. However, even stones with prominent inclusions are regularly cut for use in jewellery, and are considered beautiful objects in their own right.



Only around 30 per cent of diamonds mined worldwide are classified as being of gem quality